How Social Media Hollowed the Signal Before Generative AI

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The aesthetic critique of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) has largely proceeded synchronically, describing what these systems produce and how they redistribute creative agency. This article argues that such accounts share a blind spot. They do not explain how audiences and creators became ready for frictionless visual perfection in the first place. Adopting a genealogical approach, it contends that the conditions for GenAI's aesthetic ascendancy were prepared over the preceding decade of platform capitalism, which cultivated rather than merely accommodated an appetite for immediacy and legibility in visual culture. Two claims follow. First, algorithmic feedback and the quantification of approval had already converted creators' own wanted labour into metricised, platform-facing work well before generative tools existed, so GenAI arrived as a culmination rather than a disruption, and its encroachment on creative work people wanted to do is continuous with that earlier conversion rather than a new betrayal. Second, the historically conditioned reflex equating visual sophistication with human skill persists at both individual and institutional scale after its referent has been hollowed out, and institutions now trade on that residual authority. The article introduces an ideal-conditions stipulation to separate technical and legal grievances from philosophical ones, confronts the precedent of photography directly, and argues that the emerging counter-movement toward imperfection and provenance is a coherent response to a culturally engineered condition rather than nostalgia.

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1 Introduction

There is a puzzle at the centre of the current debate about generative artificial intelligence and visual culture. Beauty was once understood to index the labour, the judgment, and the specific encounter with a subject that lay behind a polished image. That understanding is no longer reliable. Generative AI systems now produce images that are technically sophisticated, immediately legible, and aesthetically appealing, images that satisfy every visible criterion of accomplishment without any of the processes that accomplishment once indexed. The signal of quality keeps arriving; the referent it once pointed to is no longer necessarily there.

The puzzle lies less in the technological shift than in how we received it. The tools became publicly accessible around 2022, and within months, generated images were circulating in creative communities, advertising, editorial contexts, and award competitions, read by many audiences in much the same evaluative register as images produced by human practitioners. That reading was not universal, and Section 3.3 describes a case where it provoked immediate, vocal objection. But the objection was retrospective, arriving after the fact and contesting a single result, rather than displacing the default register in which audiences received generated images day to day. Audiences did not have to learn to accept the frictionless aesthetic; it arrived into conditions in which they had already been learning, for more than a decade, to respond to exactly that kind of image. The question the aesthetics literature has not adequately addressed is why those conditions were already in place.

The aesthetic critique of GenAI has largely addressed what this means now, asking what these systems produce, how they redistribute creative agency, and which categories of authorship and value survive

the change. These accounts are often accurate and important. But they share a blind spot. They do not ask how audiences and creators became ready for frictionless visual perfection in the first place. They treat the appetite for the frictionless image as a given, the background against which GenAI's arrival is described, rather than as something that itself requires explanation.

This article offers that explanation. It argues that platform capitalism (Srnicek, 2017) prepared the conditions for GenAI's aesthetic ascendancy in the years before the technology became widely available, cultivating rather than merely accommodating an appetite for immediacy and legibility in visual culture. GenAI did not create the aesthetic crisis; it arrived into conditions that had been prepared for it.

The argument makes two main claims. First, algorithmic feedback and the quantification of approval had already converted creators' own wanted labour into metricised, platform-facing work before generative tools existed. GenAI's encroachment on creative work is continuous with that earlier conversion rather than a new betrayal; the boundary the liberation narrative of automation assumed — between the wanted labour automation would leave alone and the unwanted labour it would absorb — had already been crossed. Second, the historically conditioned reflex equating visual sophistication with human skill persists at both individual and institutional scale after its referent has been hollowed out. Institutions now supply, through accumulated authority, the legitimation that the index once provided automatically.

The method is genealogical, in the sense that Section 2.3 sets out, asking how a particular way of judging images came to feel natural, by tracing the conditions that made it available and rewarded it. The contribution is therefore to the history of reception and of creative labour, not to the literature on what generative systems produce. Answering the question posed here means looking backward rather than describing the present, and attending to the formation of evaluative habits rather than to the properties of the technology that now benefits from them.

The argument proceeds as follows. Section 2 situates the article against existing accounts and introduces the ideal-conditions stipulation that defines its object. Section 3 traces the prepared ground, from the historical index between visual sophistication and skill, through the photography precedent, to the platform conditioning that cultivated the appetite for the frictionless image. Section 4 describes the hollowed signal at individual and institutional scale. Section 5 argues that the emerging counter-movement toward imperfection and provenance is a coherent response to a culturally engineered condition, not nostalgia. Section 6 draws the conclusion.

2 The missing question

2.1 The synchronic frame

The dominant mode of GenAI aesthetics scholarship is synchronic, meaning it describes the present state of things rather than how that state came about. It asks what these systems currently produce, how they distribute creative agency, and what the outputs mean for existing categories of authorship and value. The literature is sophisticated, and the descriptions are often accurate. Three contributions are representative.

Manovich and Arielli (2024, p. 186) suggest that kitsch may function as the default aesthetic of generative AI — a careful, hedged proposal, not a named doctrine, rooted in Greenberg (1939)'s earlier argument that kitsch is defined by mechanical and formulaic processes that simulate the effects of art without the conditions that produce it. The affinity they identify is structural. Generative models cluster outputs around the recognisable and immediately appealing, which is precisely what Greenberg described the kitsch method as doing. The claim describes a tendency; it passes no verdict on any particular output.

D'Isa (2024, 2025) develops the concept of semantic attractors, by which the latent-space geometry of a trained model exerts a gravitational force on outputs, pulling them toward the high-density regions of the training distribution. The pull belongs to the space itself; no agent chooses it. The implication is that aesthetic convergence is structural rather than incidental, and that it will persist across improvements in model quality so long as the method involves statistical recombination of an existing corpus.

Post-structural accounts of distributed authorship engage GenAI as a case that enacts, at industrial scale, what Barthes (1977) proposed as a theoretical position: the death of the author as a determinant of meaning. D'Isa (2025) develops this for images specifically, through the semantic-attractor model already introduced. The clearest published statement of the general position is Islam and Uddin (2026), who argue that GenAI-assisted production is better understood as entangled hybrid authorship, an outcome of ongoing interaction between human and machine agency rather than a solo human creation, drawing on posthumanist and poststructuralist theory to reframe authorship as relational. Their argument is developed for text rather than images, and the fit with the visual case this article makes is not exact; the underlying claim, that distributed authorship displaces rather than merely modifies the question of authorial intention, transfers across the two media. Together these accounts read GenAI as the condition in which that question becomes literally unanswerable, and ask what categories of value survive the collapse.

2.2 The infrastructural frame

A second, less developed frame approaches GenAI aesthetics through political economy. Kemper (2025) analyses generative AI's everyday aesthetic production through Brand and Wissen (2021)'s concept of the imperial mode of living and Stiegler (2018)'s informational entropy. Kemper argues that the commercial fantasy of frictionlessness and immediacy sustaining GenAI's market proposition carries an environmental cost that is systematically externalised. The energy, water, and hardware extraction required to deliver apparently effortless image generation are borne by populations and ecologies that do not benefit from the product.

The difference between Kemper's account and this one is a difference of direction, and it is worth stating plainly so that the two do not collapse into a single claim. Kemper's causal arrow runs forward from GenAI firms. Marketing frictionlessness drives consumption, consumption drives extraction, and extraction imposes costs on distant populations and environments. This article's arrow runs the other way and starts earlier. The commercial fantasy of frictionlessness could only take hold in a market already disposed to want it, and that disposition was cultivated by a long run of platform capitalism operating on audiences and creators. Figure 1 sets the two arrows on one timeline. They are compatible rather than competing. Kemper explains how the fantasy is sustained and at what cost; this article explains how the appetite for it was produced.

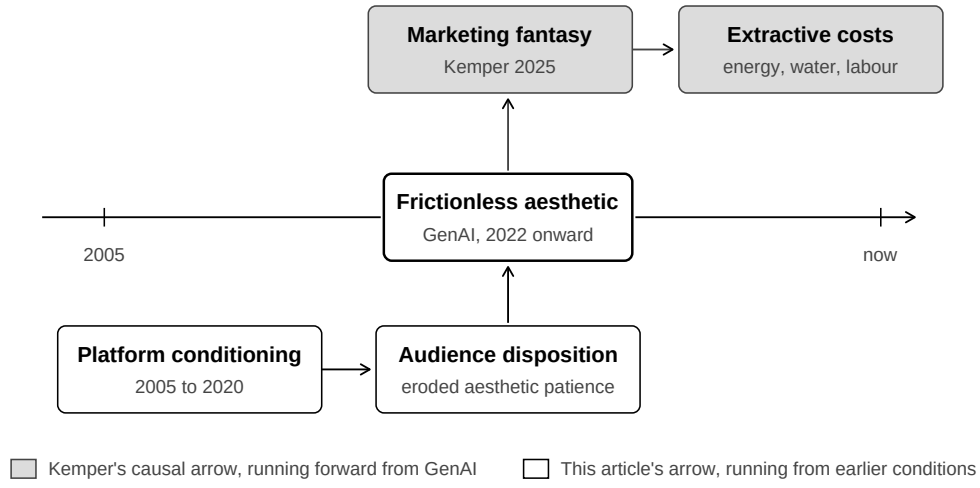


Figure 1: Two causal accounts compatible rather than competing: Kemper's arrow runs forward from GenAI's marketing of frictionlessness to environmental cost; this article's arrow runs backward from platform conditioning to audience disposition. Both converge on the frictionless aesthetic from opposite directions in time.

2.3 The missing question and the genealogical method

What neither frame asks is where the disposition came from. The synchronic accounts describe the condition accurately; the infrastructural account explains its costs; neither addresses how the evaluative habits that make GenAI's aesthetic proposition legible and appealing in the first place were historically formed. That is the missing question.

The method adopted here is genealogical in Foucault (1977)'s sense, though the mechanism it traces owes more to Ogburn (1922)'s account of cultural lag and Bourdieu (1984)'s account of habitus than to Foucault's attention to discontinuity and the emergence of new categories of judgment; genealogical is retained here for the orientation it names, tracing how a disposition came to feel natural rather than searching for the moment a new one appeared. A genealogy in this narrower sense does not search for an origin, and it does not assert that one state of affairs produced another through a recoverable causal chain. It traces how a disposition precipitates, how a particular way of perceiving and judging becomes, for a specific population over a specific period, the default way. Dispositions of this kind, close to what Bourdieu (1984) calls habitus, form without being taught, through repeated encounter with conditions that reward certain responses and make the alternatives invisible or costly. The disposition at issue here is a taste for immediacy, for high legibility, for visual approval that can be measured in real time. The claim is that more than a decade of platform-mediated image circulation created exactly the conditions under which such a taste would form, and that it left a residue in how audiences now approach generated images, a trained reflex whose formation preceded the tool that now benefits from it.

The claim is proportionate to the method. Platform culture prepared conditions of reception and creative labour. It did not make GenAI inevitable, and nothing here supposes that the outcome was planned or intended. Not more than that.

The evidence this method accepts is accordingly different from what empirical social science would require, and it is worth being precise about what kind of gap that leaves. Manovich (2017)'s analysis documents patterns in images, not in audiences, and stops short of claiming the algorithm as sole driver. De and Lu (2024) document creators adjusting their own practice, which is evidence of the platform-facing conversion described in Section 3.2, but is not, on its own, evidence that audiences' capacity to evaluate images changed. No study observes the audience-side disposition directly; dispositions rarely leave the kind of record that would support direct measurement across a population. What the argument establishes instead is that the conditions under which images circulated and were judged changed in ways well documented at the level of platforms and creators, and it infers from those conditions, rather than measures directly, that the evaluative habits of the audiences immersed in them changed as well. That inference is the weakest joint in the argument and the place most open to a study this article does not itself provide. The cultural episodes in Section 3.3 and Section 4 do not supply that missing measurement; they are consistent with the inference, which is what the method claims and what the argument, absent that further study, can currently support.

2.4 What this article is and is not arguing

Before the argument can proceed, it needs a boundary. GenAI's critics have assembled a formidable inventory of grievances: the energy and water demands of large-scale inference, the carbon cost of training runs (Strubell et al., 2019), the extractive sourcing of hardware; the use of copyrighted and personal material in training data without consent or compensation; the exploitation of labellers doing traumatic content-moderation work at low wages (Perrigo, 2023); the demographic and cultural biases baked into model outputs; the use of real likenesses without consent; the direct market displacement of illustrators, photographers, and designers who find their skills commoditised. These are serious harms. This article does not deny them.

It sets them aside.

The ideal-conditions stipulation asks the reader to grant, hypothetically, that all of those problems have been solved. Energy is clean, and consumption is proportionate. Training data was licensed or created with consent; artists are compensated; labellers work under fair conditions. Bias has been reduced to acceptable levels. Likenesses are used only with permission. The market has adjusted and displaced workers have found new roles. Assume all of that. What remains?

What remains is the article's actual subject.

Inside the bracket, several problems survive the stipulation intact. The first is aesthetic convergence, the structural tendency of statistical recombination to cluster outputs around the high-density regions of a training distribution, producing a centre of gravity that is no particular image yet pulls every output toward a recognisable visual average. The tendency belongs to the method, whatever its ethics, and clean training data does not remove it. The second is an intentionality vacuum. Generative outputs are not the product of any agent choosing this image rather than that one because of what the choice means; the model samples, and does not decide. The third is the persistence of the authorship reflex, by which audiences and institutions continue to evaluate outputs through a framework developed for artifacts with a choosing subject behind them. The fourth is the irreversibility of conditioning, since a generation of platform-shaped aesthetic reception is not undone by a policy change or a licensing agreement. The fifth is the aura problem. The desire for contact with a human process, for an image that is evidence of someone's specific encounter with the world, intensifies rather than dissolves under clean conditions, because clean conditions make plain that what is missing is no legal wrong but a different kind of thing entirely.

To state the author's position plainly, this is not an anti-AI argument. The stipulation defines the article's object. Scholars and practitioners who find the legal and technical grievances to be the most urgent concerns are not wrong to prioritise them. This article addresses a different question — one that those grievances, if resolved, would leave standing.

One further boundary. The provenance distinction will matter later and is cleaner to establish here. Provenance as legal remedy (attribution, compensation, consent, the chain of custody for training data) falls inside the stipulated bracket and stays there. Provenance as aesthetic value (the audience's interest in knowing that a human being chose) is this article's subject in Section 5, and is not the same claim. The two are easy to conflate because both involve asking "who made this?", but they ask it for different reasons and would be satisfied by different answers.

3 The prepared ground

3.1 Beauty as index, and the photography precedent

Visual sophistication has functioned, for most of recorded cultural history, as an index of the labour, the judgment, and the specific encounter with a subject that the image encodes. Baxandall (1972) documents one well-recorded episode, in which fifteenth-century patrons stopped paying for costly pigments and began paying for the skill of the painter's hand. Two working terms need to be defined here and held throughout. The *index* is the relation by which the polished image stands for the labour and judgment behind it, as a footprint stands for the foot that made it, or smoke for fire, in Peirce (1998)'s account of the indexical sign. The *signal* is what the audience receives and acts on, the polish itself read as evidence of skill. When the index is intact, signal and referent travel together, and to see a technically accomplished image was, reliably, to be in contact with accomplished labour. The title's claim, and the argument's, is that platform conditioning allowed the signal to keep arriving after the index had been emptied out. Throughout what follows, *index* names the relation and its state (intact, partial, hollowed), and *signal* names what the audience reads.

A standard objection presents itself at this point, and the argument cannot proceed until it has been answered rather than merely acknowledged. Photography and the readymade severed the hand from art-making more than a century ago, to loud alarm at the time; Baudelaire (1980) called photography art's most mortal enemy, and art survived. Duchamp did not manufacture the urinal he exhibited as *Fountain* in 1917; Edward Weston did not grind his own lenses. If the index was broken then and culture recovered, why is the present situation different?

The answer has two parts. The first concerns what was displaced. Photography removed the hand but left the eye. The photographer did not fabricate the light, yet chose the frame, the moment, the aperture, the print. The readymade removed the making but left the choosing. Duchamp did not fabricate the object, yet selected *this* object, *here*, for *these* reasons, a decision so deliberate that it became the entire point. In both cases, the displacement was partial. One dimension of human agency was removed, and the remaining dimension was foregrounded, even amplified, as the locus of artistic value. The photograph is evidence of an eye; the readymade is evidence of a concept. The index did not disappear; it relocated. Generative systems remove both dimensions at once. No hand fabricates, and no eye selects. The model samples from a distribution, and the prompt, however carefully written,

specifies a region of that distribution rather than choosing an image. The index has nowhere left to relocate.

The second part concerns who was watching. On its own, the first part would predict a crisis like the one photography provoked, followed by a renegotiation that Benjamin (2008) traces in his short history of the medium. What makes the present situation different is that the audience's capacity to notice the absence, to ask what a human being meant by this image rather than that one, had already been eroded before the tool arrived. More than a decade of platform circulation had trained audiences to evaluate images by immediate legibility and measurable approval, in conditions where the act of choosing was invisible and the platform surfaced only the outcome. The genealogical point depends on this sequence. GenAI did not arrive into an intact evaluative culture and damage it. It arrived in a culture already prepared to receive it.

Figure 2 traces the index through its three states while holding the audience's inference constant. The constancy of that inference while the referent empties out is the argument's central claim, and the third panel is its object.

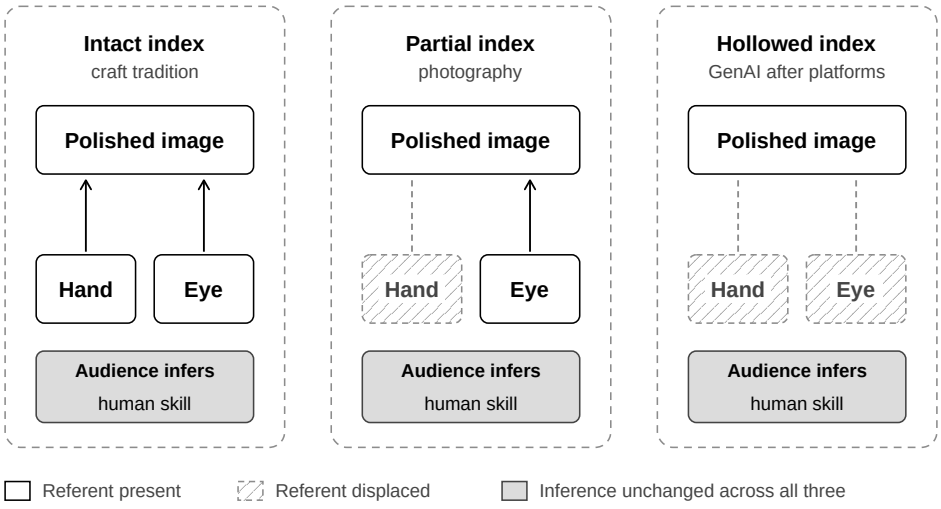


Figure 2: The index in three states. The audience's inference (bottom row) remains constant across all three panels; the changing element is the referent the index points to. Panel three—the hollowed index—is the article's object.

3.2 Engineering the appetite

Social media is the paradigm case of a wider platform logic. Chayka (2024)'s argument in *Filterworld*, for instance, spans Spotify, Netflix, and Airbnb as well as Instagram and TikTok, because the flattening tendency he identifies belongs to algorithmic recommendation at scale wherever it operates. "Platform" is the article's analytic term from this point; the title's "social media" names where the evidence comes from, and the argument is wider than the name.

The mechanism is by now well described at the macro level. Manovich (2017)'s computational analysis of roughly sixteen million Instagram photographs across seventeen cities documented recurring, platform-specific visual patterns at scale. He found less a convergence on a single style than a narrowing toward qualities the platform's structure rewarded, including clean composition, immediate legibility, and an emotional register that reads quickly. Manovich was cautious about causation and did not claim the algorithm as sole driver. But the pattern was there, at scale, in the data. Chayka (2024) provides the book-length qualitative argument that fills in the mechanism. Algorithmic recommendation systems surface content based on engagement signals, engagement signals reward immediate legibility over complexity, and creators, rational actors in an attention

economy, adjust. The result is a cultural environment in which aesthetic patience goes unrewarded and, worse, is penalised by the distribution infrastructure.

The quantification of approval accelerated this. A photograph on Instagram does not simply circulate; it receives a number, and the number is itself an economic instrument (Gerlitz and Helmond, 2013). It is public, immediate, and attached to the image rather than to any critical assessment. The like count measures the rate at which an image triggered a specific low-friction response in a specific population of viewers over a specific window of time, which is a different thing from quality in any traditional aesthetic sense. Treating it as a quality signal is a category error that the platform's design made nearly unavoidable, because no other signal was provided with equal clarity and immediacy.

The deeper displacement was in what creators learned to optimise for and what audiences learned to use as a proxy for value, more than in what images looked like, though it affected that too. The quantified approval score became the surrogate for aesthetic judgment in conditions where aesthetic judgment took time and attention that the platform's architecture did not support. Leaver et al. (2020) map the broader landscape of Instagram's visual culture in which this substitution took hold, from the platform's affordances and the norms that crystallised around them to the ways in which visibility became tied to a legibility logic that was structural before it was analysed. Their account provides the institutional context for the mechanism; what it does not yet capture, because the data were not available, is the creator-side adjustment at the level of individual practice.

The empirical granularity for that adjustment comes from a peer-reviewed study. De and Lu (2024)'s research into Instagram's poetry community — one of the platform's own creative subcultures — documented novice poets conforming the form, length, and subject matter of their work to the constraints the algorithm rewarded for visibility, in direct tension with their own stated values of originality and authentic expression. De and Lu describe this as *algorithmically mediated creative labour*, creative work whose shape answers to the operational requirements of the distribution system before it answers to the creator's intentions or a human audience's expectations. The poets in their study chose to adjust, under no compulsion, because the platform's feedback structure made visibility contingent on adjustment, and visibility was what the platform offered in place of other forms of recognition.

This account should not be overstated into a claim that aesthetic patience disappeared from the culture generally. The same years produced prestige television built on serial complexity, feature-length video essays with sustained audiences, and cinephile communities organised around Letterboxd and similar platforms, none of which optimise for the single-glance legibility described above. The distinction that matters is between the default, high-traffic circulation infrastructure that most image-making passed through and the self-selecting spaces that still rewarded patience. The latter did not disappear; they became opt-in destinations for audiences who sought them out, rather than the ambient condition under which most images were made, seen, and judged. The claim advanced here concerns that ambient condition, not the total available range of aesthetic experience, and the exceptions are evidence of the capacity described in Section 3.4 as displaced rather than destroyed.

This is the conversion this article is tracking. The labour is wanted; these are people choosing to write poetry, an activity with no extrinsic reward in ordinary conditions. The conversion leaves the labour wanted and turns it platform-facing, so that it answers to the algorithm's blunt signal where it once answered to a human reader's complex response. The creative act is still happening; it has been reconfigured around an audience that is not an audience in the traditional sense.

3.3 The prepared overshoot

The standard liberation narrative of automation, which has its classic statement in Keynes's 1930 forecast of a fifteen-hour working week (Keynes, 1963), rests on a distinction between wanted and unwanted labour. Machines absorb the tedious, the repetitive, the physically dangerous, the cognitively routine (everything on the unwanted side of the boundary) and liberate human energy for the work people actually want to do. Creative labour was supposed to be safely on the wanted side. In that framing, it was where automation was taking us, never what automation would take.

Section 3.2 has already shown that this boundary was dissolving before generative tools existed. Platform conditioning changed more than what images looked like. It converted wanted creative labour (the kind poets do, the kind photographers and illustrators and designers do) into metricised, algorithm-facing work. The optimisation pressure paid no attention to the boundary the liberation

narrative assumed; it operated wherever the platform reached, and the platform reached everywhere creative work circulated publicly. The overshoot into wanted creative labour by GenAI is, on this account, continuous with that earlier conversion rather than a new betrayal. The ground had already been prepared.

A case makes the hinge visible. In 2022, Jason M. Allen entered *Théâtre d'Opéra Spatial*, an image generated with Midjourney, in the digital arts category of the Colorado State Fair's fine art competition, and took the blue ribbon. Roose (2022), reporting for *The New York Times*, describes what followed. Artists accused Allen of cheating and objected that a machine-generated image had beaten work they had made themselves. Allen's response, that he had broken no rule, was accurate as far as it went; Roose reports that the category did not prohibit AI-assisted work and that Allen had entered under a name that named Midjourney alongside his own.

Set aside the copyright question, which Section 2.4 has bracketed, and the question of competitive fairness, real as it is. The case's analytical interest lies in what the backlash revealed about the audience's evaluative framework. The artists who objected were reading *Théâtre d'Opéra Spatial* through the index, taking the accomplishment of the image as evidence of the skill and labour of the person who submitted it. That inference is old, far older than any platform. The platform trained everyone to stop checking it, because for as long as most users could remember, a polished image carried a number, and the number stood in for the question. Allen had taken the blue ribbon by satisfying the signal without supplying the referent. The backlash was the moment the index was caught failing.

3.4 Reading the platform as attractor

On this account, the algorithm operated as a convergence mechanism before the generative model existed. The logic is the same. A system with an algorithmic reward pulls inputs toward the high-density regions of the space it governs, penalises outliers, and produces, over time, a distributional centre of gravity that is no particular output yet shapes all of them. The recommendation algorithm did this to cultural production. The generative model does the same for image synthesis. The substrate differs; the structure is identical.

Pasquinelli's labour theory of automation offers the theoretical grounding for why this matters. Pasquinelli (2023, 2025) argues against the standard view of AI as imitation of biological intelligence, and for a view in which the machine's inner logic is shaped by the intelligence of labour and social relations, specifically by the accumulated decisions, measurements, and optimisations that human productive activity has encoded into quantifiable form. The machine does not model the world; it models what labour has already extracted from the world and made legible as data. Extended to reception, the same logic says that platform capitalism extracted more than attention: it extracted the capacity for aesthetic friction, the willingness to engage with work that did not immediately resolve. This is not a claim that audiences came to prefer easier images in any reflective sense. The recommendation algorithm extracted a pattern of response: a trained disposition encoded by the platform's feedback architecture and reinforced by rewarding its expression while making alternatives structurally invisible. Extracted here means displaced, not destroyed. The capacity survived; the conditions for its exercise did not.

The distinction carries weight for the counter-movement this article discusses in Section 5. If what was lost was the conditions rather than the capacity, restoration is possible without requiring audiences to acquire new competences; it requires restoring the conditions in which existing competences can operate, which is precisely what the initiatives described in Section 5.2 are attempting, at technical, market, and cultural levels.

The implication is that better models will not transcend GenAI's convergent aesthetic, because it is a structural feature of the method. Statistical recombination clusters around the high-density regions of a training distribution by design, and a culture shaped by platform conditioning has already come to prefer exactly those regions. Supply and demand were shaped by the same logic, arriving from different directions. Figure 3 sets the two loops side by side. Whether generated outputs also re-enter training corpora, with the narrowing that Shumailov et al. (2024) document, is a further question the figure does not address.

This convergence from opposite ends is the genealogical argument's payoff. The recommendation algorithm shaped what audiences expected and what creators produced, moving the cultural distribu-

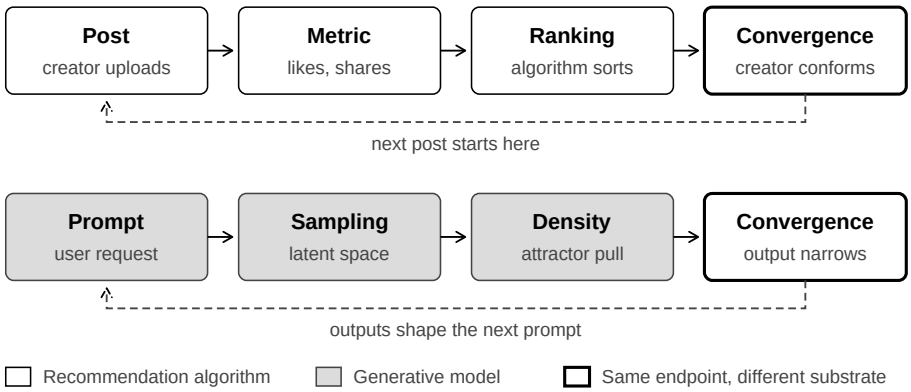


Figure 3: Two attractor loops of identical structure: algorithmic recommendation (left) and generative sampling (right). The isomorphism is not coincidental; it is the trace of a common convergence logic operating across two decades on two different registers of the same cultural system.

tion toward the immediately legible. The generative model, trained on a corpus already shaped by that distribution and received by an audience already conditioned by it, lands in exactly the centre of the space both processes had already cleared. GenAI's frictionless aesthetic did not have to overcome resistance; the resistance had already been eroded. This is what it means to say the ground was prepared. Nobody planned the outcome; each contingent step, the quantified like, the algorithmic feed, the platform-facing adjustment of creative labour, narrowed the distance between where the culture was and where the generative model would arrive. The isomorphism traces a common logic operating over the same span of years on two registers of the same cultural system.

4 The hollowed signal

4.1 Kitsch, satiety, and the automated formula

Greenberg (1939), writing in *Partisan Review*, defined kitsch as the product of mechanical and formulaic processes, a simulated experience of culture for audiences who lack the time or formation to engage with the genuine article. Greenberg targeted the mass-produced popular culture of the 1930s; he argued that kitsch works by simulating the *effects* of art (the emotional response, the sensation of quality) without the conditions that produced them. The simulation is built into the method; it needs no deceiver.

This affinity leads Manovich and Arielli (2024, p. 186), as Section 2.1 noted, to suggest that kitsch may be generative AI's default aesthetic. What the kitsch method and the generative method share is not a preference for the average but an indifference to the particular. Manovich and Arielli's hedge is well placed: the model has no taste. It samples from a distribution whose centre is an average, and outputs gather near that centre because that is where the probability mass sits. Particularity — the specific choice that could have gone otherwise — is by definition a statistical outlier, and the method is built to move away from outliers. This is why the output looks accomplished while lacking what accomplished work has. D'Isa (2024)'s semantic attractors name the same pull from the model's side.

The aesthetic consequence is what Greenberg anticipated under a different name. Visual splendour becomes abundant and cheap, and unearned beauty produces satiety rather than engagement. Ghafouri (2025) offers formal corroboration from information theory, arguing that variance reduction in generative systems measurably narrows the output distribution over time. This corroborates the aesthetic claim without founding it. The foundation is the structural affinity between the generative method and the kitsch method as Greenberg described it, since both maximise the signal of quality while minimising the particularity that would make that quality cost something.

Superficial perfection and structural incoherence can coexist in a generated image in a way that would be nearly impossible for a skilled human practitioner. The lighting is accomplished; the fingers are wrong. The composition holds; the background architecture violates its own logic. Such errors have nothing to do with carelessness. They are the signature of a process that optimises local coherence without a model of the whole, so that the outputs are polished at the level of detail and incoherent at the level of structure. Under a fully intact index, such an image would be self-defeating, since the structural incoherence would read as evidence of limited skill. Under the hollowed index, it often does not, because the audience's evaluative apparatus has been trained to respond to the local signal rather than to assess the whole.

This tolerance for local coherence without structural integrity predates the generative model. It was trained into reception by the conditions described in Section 3.2, in which the platform reward for immediate legibility favoured images that read clearly in a small format, at a glance, within a scrolling feed, conditions where detail assessment is the only assessment that happens. Structural integrity, which requires sustained attention and contextual knowledge, was progressively removed from the conditions under which images were evaluated publicly. The structural incoherence of the generated image is legible as a limitation only to a viewer who looks for the whole—and platform architecture had steadily reduced the incentive to look for the whole long before the tool existed.

4.2 Cultural lag at the individual scale

Foucault (1998)'s author function names the mechanism by which prestige and value attach to the name rather than the text. The author, in this sense, is less the person who wrote than the institutional position that licenses a certain reading, confers seriousness, and determines how disagreements about meaning are resolved. The function is historical. It did not exist before a certain period of European legal and literary culture; it is not intrinsic to any artifact, but conferred. Barthes (1977) announced the death of the author as a theoretical proposition, holding that once the reader exists, the author's intention ceases to govern meaning. GenAI enacts that proposition as an industrial condition at scale, which is different from validating it. The question the paper returns to at each stage is what remains of the human within the creative machinery after the author function has been decoupled from any actual human agent.

The authorship reflex (the habit of reading a polished image as evidence of a skilled human behind it) persists after its referent has been hollowed out. The Allen case, already described in Section 3.3, showed this at the scale of one artist and one contest. The audience was applying the reflex correctly by its own logic: the image was accomplished; therefore someone accomplished made it, and the reflex did not fail. What failed was the index it relied on, which had been decoupled from what the reflex assumed. Cultural lag, in Ogburn (1922)'s original sense, names the gap between the persistence of a habit and the disappearance of the conditions that made it reliable. At the individual scale, the lag is panel three of Figure 2, where the inference runs on, unchanged, while the referent has changed entirely.

The lag runs through creators as well as audiences. For practitioners formed in a tradition where visual sophistication was tied to their own labour, a tool that produces sophistication without that labour does not dissolve the equation. Many still feel that the polished image represents something the person submitting it has not earned, because the framework they work within was built on the assumption that polish costs the maker something. The feeling is the intact index's response to a world in which the index has been decoupled, and there is nothing irrational in it. The lag at the creator scale is the persistence of a professional identity, an understanding of what one's work means and what it costs, in conditions that have altered the external basis of that identity without erasing the internal one. The question of what the human retains within the creative machinery, what the creative act still is if not what it was, becomes urgent here precisely because the reflex alone cannot answer it.

4.3 Cultural lag at the institutional scale

Christie's held a sale titled *Augmented Intelligence* from 20 February to 5 March 2025, comprising 34 lots spanning work from the 1960s to the present. The sale realised $728,784 with fees against a pre-sale low estimate of $600,000 without fees; 28 lots sold and six did not; 37% of registered bidders were new to the house, and 48% were Millennials or Generation Z (Brady, 2025). An open

letter posted on 8 February, before the sale opened, gathered almost 6,500 signatures calling for its cancellation (Porterfield, 2025).

Three interpretive limits must be observed before any analytical claim is made. First, Christie's stated that the artists had strong existing multidisciplinary practices, some represented in leading museum collections, and were using AI as one element within established bodies of work. That is a credible account, and it defeats any reading of the sale as a misrepresentation of talent; the artists are not the target of this analysis. Second, Brady (2025) characterises the total as middling, and the highest-estimated lot failed to sell; the sale was not an unambiguous commercial triumph. Third, the open letter's primary grievance was copyright, which Section 2.4 has stipulated away. Noting this does not dismiss the grievance; it maintains the boundary the article drew at the outset.

The defensible claim is narrower than any of these points, and more interesting. Christie's supplied, through its accumulated institutional authority, the legitimation that provenance alone could no longer settle. The auction house's imprimatur, its history, its prestige, its role as arbiter of market value in the art world, was doing the work that the index, were it intact, would have done automatically. The institutional author function was filling the vacancy left by the hollowed index. The lag operates here at the scale of the institution rather than the individual, the same reflex as the Allen case one level up. The fact that the sale was contested and only partly successful fits the reading, since the institution's authority was working, but not effortlessly. The residual authority was real; so was the friction.

This differs from Duro (2025)'s analysis of AI-generated beauty standards, which examines how generative systems encode and reproduce norms about represented bodies. That asks what is depicted; this asks how authorship is conferred. The two concerns are adjacent but separate.

Christie's operated a mechanism the culture had built before anyone knew it would need to do this kind of work. It is panel three at institutional scale, and no one was defrauded.

5 Reclamation, not nostalgia

5.1 Aura reconsidered: a deliberate reversal

Benjamin (2008)'s account of the aura, the sense of a work's unique presence in a particular place and time and its embeddedness in a tradition of making and a history of use, was not a lament. Benjamin's own valence on the decline of aura under mechanical reproduction was ambivalent, tending toward positive, since he read the destruction of aura as potentially emancipatory, stripping away the cult value that had kept art in the service of ritual, class distinction, and political mythology. The photograph and the film, by making reproduction cheap and universal, could, in principle, democratise culture.

This article inverts that valence, and says so, because silently borrowing Benjamin's vocabulary while discarding his conclusion would invite a justified objection. Section 3 and Section 4 license the inversion. On the reading proposed here, Benjamin's emancipatory account of aura's decline presupposed an audience that could meet the democratised image on its own terms once the ritual scaffolding of cult value was gone. Benjamin (2008) himself welcomed what he called reception in distraction, the habitual, half-attentive mode in which a public absorbs architecture or film; but distraction, for him, was still a way of becoming practised in a new medium. Platform conditioning offered no such practice. It replaced the exercise of judgment with a number, and it had been doing so long before GenAI arrived. Under those conditions, the return of interest in aura answers a specifically damaged capacity; it is neither reactionary nor a general nostalgia for a better past.

5.2 What the counter-movement actually looks like

The counter-movement against frictionless visual perfection is real, and sentiment is the least of it. It takes concrete form in at least three registers.

The Coalition for Content Provenance and Authenticity (C2PA) has developed Content Credentials, a technical standard for embedding cryptographically signed metadata in image files that records the tools used, the edits made, and whether a human or an automated system was responsible at each stage (Coalition for Content Provenance and Authenticity (C2PA), 2024). The standard is not yet universal, and adoption across platforms is uneven, but it is a serious infrastructural attempt to restore a legible chain of custody to digital images and make the index readable again at a technical level.

Labels declaring work to be human-made express the same impulse at the market level. The Authors Guild launched a "Human Authored" certification for books in January 2025 (Knight, 2025), and by early 2026 BBC News counted at least eight competing initiatives, with marks such as "Proudly Human" and "AI-free" appearing on films, books, marketing, and websites (Tidy, 2026). The labels are crude, their definitions conflict, and verification is difficult, but they answer a stated preference for verified human process that quantified approval had previously made invisible.

The revival of analogue photography is a third register, and its timing needs to be stated honestly rather than smoothed over. Industry reporting places the start of the revival around 2010–15, a decade before generative tools existed, with growth accelerating sharply from around 2020 and continuing through the years generative tools became available (Chemical & Engineering News, 2026). The earlier phase supports, not contradicts, the account in Section 3.4: the capacity for aesthetic patience survived platform conditioning throughout, displaced into a niche market rather than destroyed. The later acceleration, coinciding with and continuing past GenAI's arrival, is the more direct evidence for this section's claim, consistent with a market responding to the new abundance of synthetic imagery by seeking out its opposite. Practitioners who choose film in an era of free digital generation are choosing constraint, process, and the irreversibility of a physical encounter with light. The choice states what kind of evidence a photograph should be: evidence of an eye, where a generated image is evidence of a sampling distribution.

These initiatives treat provenance as aesthetic value, not the legal remedy stipulated away in Section 2.4 — and a satisfied legal grievance would not satisfy the aesthetic one, because the aesthetic one concerns a different kind of contact.

5.3 What responsible practice requires

The practitioner who uses generative tools responsibly cannot do so by ignoring the structural tendencies Section 3 and Section 4 have described. The tool's convergent pull toward the high-density centre of its training distribution is a property of the method, and no amount of better prompting corrects it. Responsible use means working with the knowledge of that tendency rather than pretending it does not exist.

For creative institutions, this means the legitimation they supply through their accumulated authority (the author function at institutional scale, as Section 4.3 described it) is now visible in a way it was not before. Institutions that trade on residual authority while declining to acknowledge what that authority covers are accelerating the lag rather than addressing it. The more honest position is to ask what the institution's imprimatur is actually certifying, and to build practices around a clear answer.

For platforms, the implication is that the feedback infrastructure described in Section 3.2 (the quantification of approval, the algorithmic reward for immediate legibility) was a design choice with consequences; it produced the conditions this article has described. Nobody planned that production; it emerged from design decisions made for other reasons. But emergent consequences are still consequences, and designing differently remains possible.

For audiences, the counter-movement's most coherent form is a developed interest in process, in knowing how an image came to be as well as what it looks like, more than a preference for imperfection as such. That interest re-engages an evaluative capacity that platform architecture had made unnecessary, and nostalgia is the wrong name for it.

6 Conclusion

The puzzle this article began with, a signal of quality that still arrives after the index behind it has emptied, predates generative AI. It is the condition into which GenAI arrived. The aesthetic crisis was prepared.

The genealogical argument makes visible what synchronic accounts leave in shadow: the authorship reflex, the inference from polished image to skilled human, persists at both individual and institutional scale, because evaluative habits outlast the conditions that made them reliable, and deception plays no part in it. Cultural lag is the structural form the hollowed signal takes.

What the counter-movement toward imperfection and provenance is doing, on this account, is re-engaging a capacity that platform architecture had made unnecessary. The interest in verified human

process, in knowing that a human being chose, is an attempt to restore the index and make the signal carry the referent again, in conditions where the decoupling has become fully visible; a sentimental preference for the past has little to do with it.

A condition over a decade in the making requires a response of comparable scale. The legal and technical grievances (training-data consent, artist compensation, environmental cost) are real and urgent, and their resolution would constitute genuine progress. But their resolution would leave the philosophical questions standing, because those questions concern a different kind of thing. The grievances ask what was done without permission; the philosophical questions ask what was shaped without anyone deciding to shape it. Answering them means looking at the infrastructure of aesthetic formation, the feedback loops, the quantified approval, the reward for legibility, and not only at the outputs those systems eventually made possible.

The signal was hollowed before the model arrived. A polished image once stood for its maker the way a footprint stands for a foot, and for a generation the feed taught its audiences to admire footprints without asking who had walked there. Generative AI did not teach them that. It only made footprints that no foot had made. Whatever restoring the index will take, it has to begin with the ground.

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